# Understanding Cancer

A Comprehensive Guide to Awareness, Types, and Global Impact

## What is Cancer?

Cancer is a large group of diseases that can start in almost any organ or tissue of the body when abnormal cells grow uncontrollably, go beyond their usual boundaries to invade adjoining parts of the body and/or spread to other organs. The latter process is called metastasizing and is a major cause of death from cancer.

> **Global Impact:** Cancer is a leading cause of death worldwide, accounting for nearly 10 million deaths annually. However, many cancers can be cured if detected early and treated effectively.

## Most Common Types of Cancer

While there are over 100 types of cancer, certain types are diagnosed more frequently. The following table highlights some of the most common cancers globally:

| Cancer Type | Primary Risk Factors | Common Screening Methods |
|---|---|---|
| **Breast Cancer** | Age, genetic mutations (BRCA1/2), family history, alcohol consumption. | Mammography, clinical breast exams. |
| **Lung Cancer** | Tobacco use (primary cause), secondhand smoke, exposure to radon or asbestos. | Low-dose computed tomography (LDCT) for high-risk individuals. |
| **Colorectal Cancer** | Diet high in red/processed meats, physical inactivity, obesity, age. | Colonoscopy, stool DNA tests, fecal occult blood tests. |
| **Prostate Cancer** | Age (over 50), family history, genetics, diet. | Prostate-Specific Antigen (PSA) blood test. |

## Prevention and Risk Reduction

Between 30% and 50% of all cancer cases are preventable. Prevention offers the most cost-effective long-term strategy for the control of cancer. Below are key strategies to significantly reduce the risk of developing the disease:

### Avoid Tobacco

Tobacco use is the single greatest avoidable risk factor for cancer mortality and kills approximately 8 million people each year. Avoiding smoking and smokeless tobacco drastically reduces risks.

### Maintain a Healthy Diet

Eating plenty of fruits, vegetables, and whole grains while limiting the intake of processed meats and excessive sugar can help maintain a healthy weight and lower cancer risks.

### Physical Activity

Regular physical activity helps control weight and reduces the risk of several cancers, including breast, colon, and endometrial cancer. Aim for at least 150 minutes of moderate activity weekly.

### Vaccination

Infectious agents are responsible for a significant proportion of cancers in developing countries. Vaccines for Hepatitis B (HBV) and Human Papillomavirus (HPV) are critical prevention tools.

## The Importance of Early Detection

Cancer mortality is reduced when cases are detected and treated early. There are two components of early detection:

- **Early diagnosis:** Awareness of early signs and symptoms (for cancer types such as skin, cervical, breast, colorectal and oral) in order to get them diagnosed and treated at early stages.
- **Screening:** Identifying individuals with abnormalities suggestive of a specific cancer or pre-cancer who have not developed any symptoms and referring them promptly for diagnosis and treatment.

> **Conclusion:** While a cancer diagnosis can be daunting, advancements in medical research, targeted therapies, and global awareness campaigns are continuously improving survival rates. Education and proactive lifestyle choices remain our strongest defense.